

Day 1 — Where the Doṣas Come From

Module: Doṣas · **Band:** Middle · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

By the end of this lesson, students recall the five *pañcabhūta*, pair them into three combinations, and articulate why the body might be organised around motion, transformation, and structure.

Materials

- Whiteboard with the *pañcabhūta* diagram from Module 2 (or a printed copy)
- A small fan, a candle (unlit, for show), a stone, a glass of water, an empty box
- One blank page per student to start the *doṣa* notebook

Vocabulary introduced today

- *doṣa* (IAST: doṣa; lit. “that which can become faulty / humour”) — a biological functional principle in Ayurveda. In its natural state, it sustains the body; out of balance, it causes harm.
- *tridoṣa* (IAST: tri-doṣa; lit. “three doṣas”) — the three together: *vāta*, *pitta*, *kapha*.

Lesson flow

Warm-up (5 min)

- On the board: “Name the five elements in IAST.” Whole-class chorus.
- “What did *pr̥thvī* mean again? *Ap*? *Tejas*? *Vāyu*? *Ākāśa*?”
- “Today we ask: what happens when you combine two of them at a time? Why might the body be built that way?”

Core (20 min)

1. **Recall the five elements with the props.** Hold each up briefly:
 - stone → *pr̥thvī* (solid)
 - water glass → *ap* (liquid)
 - candle → *tejas* (heat/light)
 - fan → *vāyu* (air, moving)
 - empty box → *ākāśa* (space inside)
2. **The shift from Module 2.** Module 2 asked “what categories does *matter* come in?” Today we ask: “What categories do *bodily functions* come in?” The body is not made of *just matter* — it does things. It moves. It transforms food. It holds itself together.
3. **Three categories of doing — build on the board:**

What the body does	Need this kind of element	Pair
Moves things — breath, blood, food through gut, signals to muscles	Something that moves freely, in a space	<i>ākāśa + vāyu</i>
Transforms things — digestion (food → energy), seeing (light → image), body heat	Something that converts, with a medium	<i>tejas + ap</i>
Holds things together — bones, muscle, skin, fluids that lubricate	Something solid and cohesive	<i>ap + pṛthvī</i>

4. **Name the three pairs:**

Pair	Sanskrit name	Lit. meaning
<i>ākāśa + vāyu</i>	vāta	“wind, that-which-moves”
<i>tejas + ap</i>	pitta	“that which heats / digests”
<i>ap + pṛthvī</i>	kapha	“phlegm, that-which-holds”

5. **The Sanskrit name for the trio.** Write it: **tridoṣa**. “Three doṣas.” In classical Indian medicine, these three functional principles are how the body is organised.
6. **Source-of-record paraphrase.** “*The Caraka Saṁhitā — one of the founding Ayurveda texts, c. 1st millennium BCE/CE — says: when vāta, pitta, and kapha are in their natural state, they sustain the body; when they are out of balance, they cause disease.*” (Caraka Saṁhitā, Sūtrasthāna 1.57 — paraphrase.)
7. **What this module is not.** Read aloud the safety statement from the README: this is a vocabulary for noticing, not a diagnosis system.

Activity (15 min) — Build your tridoṣa page

- Open notebook to a fresh page. At the top, write: **tridoṣa — three doṣa**.
- Draw three columns, one per doṣa. At the top of each column write the Sanskrit name + IAST + literal meaning.
- Below each name, draw the two elements that combine. Use the Module 2 element-symbol you made earlier.
- Leave the rest of the column blank — you’ll fill it tomorrow.
- Partner check: swap notebooks with the person next to you. Read theirs out loud. Catch one mistake if you can.

Wrap-up (5 min)

- One-question exit: “Which of the three feels most like YOU right now? Don’t think hard — just one word.” Sticky note.
- Preview: “Tomorrow we fill in the rest of the columns — what each doṣa actually does in your body.”

Student-facing content

Three categories of *doing*:

Doṣa	Sanskrit	Elements	What it does
<i>vāta</i>	“wind”	<i>ākāśa + vāyu</i>	moves things
<i>pitta</i>	“heater”	<i>tejas + ap</i>	transforms things
<i>kapha</i>	“binder”	<i>ap + pṛthvī</i>	holds things

When they are in balance, they sustain the body. When they are out of balance, they cause trouble.

— Caraka Saṁhitā, *Sūtrasthāna* 1.57 (paraphrase)

Homework

- Look around your home tonight. Find **one example** for each of the three: something that *moves*, something that *transforms*, something that *holds together*. Write the three examples in your notebook.

Differentiation

- One tier up:** Why does *ap* (water) appear in TWO of the three doṣas? What does that suggest about water’s special role in the framework?
- One tier down:** Just remember the three names and what each does. The element pairing can come tomorrow.

Teacher notes

- The trickiest pairing is *kapha* = *ap* + *pṛthvī*. Students will want *pṛthvī* alone — but the classical formulation is that earth needs water to hold its cohesive structure (think: dry sand vs wet sand).
- Some students will ask why fire (*tejas*) doesn’t appear alone. Good question. The classical answer: fire by itself doesn’t transform — it needs something fluid to transform *in*. Hence *tejas* + *ap* = *pitta*.
- Don’t go deep on *prakṛti/vikṛti* today. That’s Day 3.

Citation(s) used in this lesson

- Caraka Saṁhitā, *Sūtrasthāna* 1.57 (paraphrase; see `sources.md` for full reference).